

Politicians with Local Roots and Voter Turnout

Edoardo Alberto Viganò

University Carlos III of Madrid

Abstract

A large body of research shows that voters prefer politicians with local roots, yet it remains unclear whether localness also mobilises electoral participation. This article distinguishes between two mechanisms through which local ties may matter: during campaigns, by lowering information costs, activating place-based identities, and mobilising local networks; and after elections, through political representation. Using a dataset combining municipality-level election outcomes with the birthplaces of Italian candidates, legislators, and ministers since the postwar period, I examine whether municipalities represented by local candidates, legislators, or ministers experience higher turnout. Matching, difference-in-differences, and regression discontinuity designs show that local candidates modestly increase turnout, while local MPs and ministers do not. Survey evidence supports a place-identity interpretation: the effect of local candidates is concentrated in small municipalities and among voters with stronger attachment to their hometowns. These findings suggest that local roots mobilise voters during campaigns, rather than through political representation.

Introduction

Do politicians' local roots matter for electoral participation? Voters frequently favour candidates who come from their local area, a pattern documented across different contexts (Campbell et al. 2019; Nyholt 2024; Tavits 2010). A growing body of research suggests that the effects of local roots extend beyond candidate choice: voters may also be more likely to participate when a candidate with local roots appears on the ballot (Górecki et al. 2022; Panagopoulos et al. 2017). Yet it is unclear whether local roots increase turnout because they make a candidate more salient during the campaign, or because voters value being represented by hometown politicians.

This distinction is theoretically important because localism can connect politicians to voters through two different channels. The first is a campaign mechanism, in which candidates' local origins become politically salient during campaign periods and boost participation. The second is a representation mechanism, in which voters participate because they are represented by someone who shares relevant characteristics with them and who is better positioned to advance local interests. Existing research speaks to the first, showing that voters are more likely to turn out when a locally rooted candidate contests an election and less likely to do so when such candidates withdraw (Fiva and Smith 2017; Górecki et al. 2022). However, we know much less about whether local politicians continue to mobilise voters once they hold office.¹ Moreover, existing studies on the mobilising effect of local candidates have typically looked at subnational elections, which might be a most likely case to find an effect of local roots.² Whether local ties move voters in the high-information, party-dominated environment of a national election is less clear.

In this paper I address these questions by examining the mobilisation potential of three groups of politicians with local roots – candidates, members of parliament, and ministers – in Italian national elections. By bridging the literatures on the effects of

1. Fiva et al. (2021) incidentally test whether local incumbent MPs increase turnout, but do not theorise why this might be the case.

2. To my knowledge, the only exception is Fiva and Smith (2017), who study the *withdrawal* of local candidates in historical Norwegian elections.

descriptive representation and on ‘friends-and-neighbours’ voting, I extend the focus from candidates to officeholders and ask whether local ties matter for participation beyond campaigns. I argue that local roots can mobilise voters in two ways. During campaigns, they can make candidates more salient to voters; after the election, they can create representational bonds between voters and politicians in office. Whether these bonds matter for political participation beyond the campaign, however, depends on the office politicians hold. I distinguish between ordinary legislators, whose local ties may become less visible after the election and who have limited capacity to deliver benefits to their hometowns, and cabinet ministers, who remain more visible and have more influence over the allocation of public resources.

To test these arguments, I leverage an original dataset that combines municipality-level turnout records with biographical information on the birthplaces of all Italian candidates, legislators, and ministers over the postwar period. The empirical strategy proceeds in three steps. First, an aggregate-level study estimates the effect of local candidates (1994–2018) and officeholders (1948–2018) on municipal turnout, using matching and difference-in-differences (DiD) methods. Second, to separate the effect of holding office from the impact of contesting a seat, I exploit close single-member-district races in the mixed-member elections of 1994, 1996, and 2001 in a regression discontinuity design (RDD). Third, an individual-level study (2001–2013) draws on election-survey data to explore descriptively the mechanisms behind the aggregate patterns.

The municipality-level results indicate that local candidates have a modest but significant positive effect on turnout, and this effect persists into the following election, consistent with habit formation in voting (Gerber et al. 2003). By contrast, I find no evidence that representation by a local MP raises subsequent turnout: the matching estimates are close to zero, equivalence tests rule out effects as large as those estimated for local candidates, and the close-election design suggests that narrowly electing a hometown candidate does not significantly increase turnout relative to narrowly losing. The estimates for local ministers are also insignificant, although the small number of treated municipalities makes the null results more suggestive than conclusive. Comple-

mentary survey analyses are consistent with a place-identity account: the association between local candidates and reported turnout is concentrated in smaller municipalities and among voters whose primary territorial attachment is to their own municipality.

Taken together, the findings suggest that local roots matter for participation primarily when they are electorally salient. Local candidates increase turnout, but having a local politician in office does not produce a similar increase in participation. The results therefore suggest that geographical descriptive representation does not translate into greater electoral participation. This contrasts with research showing that voters from historically underrepresented groups – such as ethnic minorities and women – can become more politically engaged when a group member holds or runs for office, through increased political efficacy and feelings of inclusion (Barreto 2007; Campbell and Wolbrecht 2006). The turnout effects of descriptive representation may therefore depend on the type of group being represented. In addition, the results speak to debates over candidate selection by showing that geographically representative candidate pools can have positive consequences for electoral participation.

Theory

The effects of local roots on electoral participation can be produced through two distinct mechanisms. The first operates through the *campaign*: local origins can make candidates more salient, provide informational cues, activate place-based identities, and facilitate mobilisation through local networks. The second operates through *representation*: voters may become more engaged when they are represented by someone from their community, either because shared characteristics foster a sense of inclusion or because local representatives are better positioned to advance local interests. These two mechanisms lead to different expectations about when and how local roots should affect participation, which I develop in the remainder of this section.

Localism and campaign mobilisation

The campaign perspective builds on the well-established literature on friends-and-neighbours voting (Key 1949) and the broader evidence that voters prefer candidates with local roots (Campbell et al. 2019; Fiva and Halse 2016; Horiuchi et al. 2020; Nyholt 2024; Schulte-Cloos and Bauer 2021; Tavits 2010). Echoing the argument that minority voters are mobilised by in-group candidates (Barreto 2007; Washington 2006), local candidacies, rather than affecting only vote choice, may also increase electoral participation. Experimental studies show that highlighting candidates' local ties boosts turnout (Panagopoulos and Bailey 2020; Panagopoulos et al. 2017), while observational studies document higher turnout when local candidates contest elections and lower turnout when they withdraw from a race (Fiva and Smith 2017; Górecki et al. 2022; Meredith 2013; Rice and Macht 1987).

With respect to candidates' local traits, campaign mobilisation can arise through several complementary mechanisms. Local ties can serve as informational shortcuts, reducing the cognitive costs of voting by offering cues about a candidate's qualities or priorities (Velimsky et al. 2024). Campaigns also activate place-based identities (i.e., a sense of attachment to a geographically defined group), making local attachments politically salient and reducing the perceived social distance between voters and candidates (Magee and Smith 2013; Panagopoulos et al. 2017; Schulte-Cloos and Bauer 2021). Finally, local candidates often possess denser social networks and campaign more intensively in their home areas, leveraging existing networks to mobilise support (Fiva and Smith 2017). Although these mechanisms differ, they share an important feature: they are tied to the election campaign. This perspective therefore predicts that turnout should increase when a local candidate contests the election.

H1 *Voters are more likely to turn out when a local candidate is running.*

Localism and representation

Local roots may affect turnout through representation. One possibility is descriptive representation: citizens may become more politically engaged when they are represented by legislators who share salient characteristics with them, increasing feelings of inclusion and political efficacy (Segura and Bowler 2005). This effect has been documented for different groups, including young people (Angelucci et al. 2024), African Americans and Latinos (Griffin and Keane 2006; Rocha et al. 2010), and immigrants (Geese 2023). By analogy, a similar logic might extend to geographic descriptive representation: voters may feel more connected to political institutions when they are represented by someone from their own local area (Fiva et al. 2021; Uhlaner 2012).

I argue, however, that the analogy is limited for geographic identities. The empowerment mechanism that the existing literature has identified for minority (e.g., ethnic and gender) groups is less likely to operate in the case of geographic identities. More specifically, the argument presupposes a politically conscious group that interprets the election of a co-member as a collective gain in standing (Bobo and Gilliam 1990). Residents of the same municipality, however, do not typically constitute such a group and rarely articulate collective representational claims. Moreover, the political salience of local roots is likely to peak during election campaigns and decrease in other periods of the election cycle (Huwyler et al. 2025). Campaigns make candidates' local origins visible and politically relevant, activating place-based identities among voters. Once the election is over, however, these cues lose relevance, since holding parliamentary office per se does not necessarily keep a politician's local origins politically salient.

Local roots may also matter through substantive representation. Constituents might think that legislators with local roots are better positioned or more willing to advance the interests of their hometown (Kovarek 2022), for instance by securing public investment or providing constituency service. If voters observe these benefits, the election of a local representative could increase their incentives to vote. Yet the capacity to represent local interests varies across political offices. Although MPs

make use of individual parliamentary activities to advance local interests (Russo 2011; Zittel et al. 2019), ordinary legislators have limited individual discretion over the allocation of public resources. Moreover, parliamentary office may even weaken the link between MPs and their local constituencies. As illustrated by Smrek (2023), MPs elected on the basis of strong local support can become more responsive to party leaders than to their local constituencies.

These arguments suggest that geographic parliamentary representation is unlikely to increase participation. Local roots are most salient during campaigns, and ordinary MPs lack the visibility to keep them salient once the election is over; at the same time, ordinary MPs have limited capacity to convert local ties into visible benefits for their hometowns.

H2 *The election of a local politician in parliament does not increase voter turnout at the next election.*

H2 concerns parliamentary office. Politicians who enter the cabinet do not face the same constraints. First, ministerial appointments increase politicians' salience and visibility in the media and their name recognition among voters (Van Aelst et al. 2008). This higher visibility provides opportunities for voters to be exposed to politicians' local origins, extending the salience of local traits beyond the campaign period. Second, ministerial office gives politicians access to resources that backbenchers lack. Ministers can engage in executive particularism, that is, 'spending secured by government ministers and targeted at their geographical constituencies, which is funded from general taxation' (Martin 2016: 285). Given their institutional position, cabinet members are better placed than backbenchers to target government resources at their hometowns (Golden and Picci 2008; Suiter and O'Malley 2014; Widmer and Zurlinden 2022). The institutional capacity of ministers therefore carries material implications: when a locally rooted politician enters the cabinet, constituents may perceive better access to government resources and stronger influence over policymaking. If such perceptions increase the expected benefits of political participation or strengthen voters' connec-

tion to their representatives, they may increase turnout at the next election (Catalinac et al. 2020; Chen 2013).

H3 *The appointment of a local politician to the cabinet increases voter turnout at the next election.*

Data and methods

Case selection

To test the arguments outlined above, I rely on data from Italian elections held between 1948 and 2022. In addition to data availability, Italy is a suitable case for exploring the relationship between local politicians and turnout for several reasons. First, the territorial dimension of representation is salient in the Italian political setting. On the one hand, MPs make wide use of individual parliamentary activities to advance local interests (Gagliarducci et al. 2011; Russo 2011). On the other hand, historically Italy has been characterised by high levels of particularism and geographically targeted distributive policies (Decadri 2021; Golden 2003).

Moreover, postwar Italy offers variation in electoral institutions. Between 1948 and 1992, an open-list PR system was employed. As a result of a deep crisis of the political system, a mixed-member majoritarian (MMM) system was introduced in 1993. This system remained in place until 2005, when closed-list PR rules were introduced. Finally, in 2017 another electoral reform re-introduced an MMM system. The systems just described vary in the extent to which candidates need to rely on their personal reputations rather than those of their parties in order to win a seat (Carey and Shugart 1995), ranging from low incentives for cultivating a personal vote under closed-list PR, to high incentives in open-list PR systems. Different sets of candidates' incentives may translate into different voting heuristics (Shugart et al. 2005), which in turn can influence turnout. While this is not the main focus of the paper, variation in electoral

rules allows me to assess whether the effects of place-based identities on turnout are conditional on electoral rules.

Taken together, these features indicate that Italy could be a most likely case to detect an effect of local politicians on turnout, particularly in the period when open-list rules were employed. At the same time, national elections might represent a hard test for the theory, since the mobilisational potential of local politicians is expected to be stronger in contexts where partisan cues are weaker and voters rely more heavily on other informational shortcuts, such as in primaries and local elections (Panagopoulos et al. 2017).

Data

The analyses consist of two studies. Study 1 employs aggregate data at the municipality level, while Study 2 conducts individual-level analyses using election surveys.³ For both studies, I compiled a dataset which includes all legislators and ministers in postwar Italy (1948–2018) and all candidates since 1994.⁴ To identify whether a municipality is treated, I rely on information about politicians' birthplaces.⁵ Accordingly, I construct three treatment variables:

1. *Candidate treatment*: municipalities where at least one candidate was born. A municipality is treated at election t if a politician born in that municipality appears on the ballot at t . This treatment is available from 1994, when candidate-level data become available.
2. *MP treatment*: municipalities that are birthplaces of incumbent MPs in the previous term. A municipality is treated at election t if a politician born in that municipality served as an MP between $t - 1$ and t .

3. See the Appendix for a description of all data sources.

4. Given that elections for the two houses are simultaneous and Italian bicameralism is symmetrical, I expect spillover effects and hence include legislators and candidates in both houses. For turnout, I focus on the lower house, which has a lower voting age requirement (18 instead of 25). The Appendix reports results restricted to the lower house only.

5. While other contributions also look at politicians' place of residence, this information is not systematically available for Italian politicians. Reassuringly, data reported in [Appendix B](#) show that a substantial share of MPs reside in their hometowns, and those who do not typically live nearby.

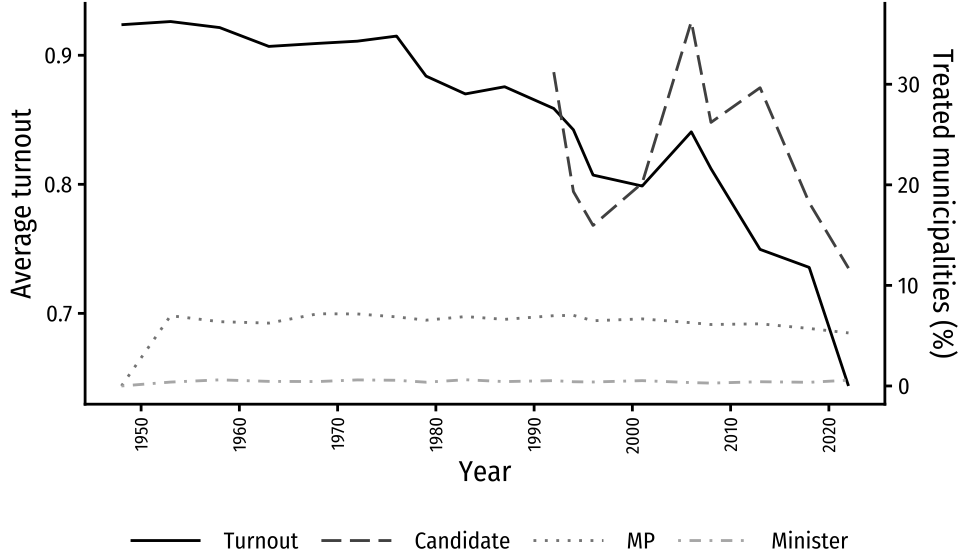


Figure 1. Average turnout and share of treated municipalities

3. *Minister treatment*: municipalities that are birthplaces of cabinet ministers in office during the previous term. A municipality is treated at election t if a politician born in that municipality held ministerial office between $t - 1$ and t .

Overall, approximately 11% of municipalities receive the candidate treatment, 6% the MP treatment, and 0.5% the minister treatment. Figure 1 visualises the time trends for turnout and the treatment variables.

For the aggregate-level study, I compiled a panel dataset at the municipality–year level, including turnout and a set of municipal-level covariates. For the individual-level analyses, I employ the Italian election survey (ITANES) data from 2001 to 2013.⁶

Estimation methods

In the aggregate analyses, I employ the matching estimator proposed by Imai et al. (2023). For each treated municipality, this estimator constructs matched sets composed of control units with identical treatment histories, further refined by covariate-based matching.⁷ The main specifications use Mahalanobis distance matching on a number

6. Surveys conducted after 2013 do not ask respondents' place of residence. This information, or other relevant control variables, were not present in survey waves prior to 2001.

7. As districts have changed frequently due to electoral reforms, analyses are conducted at the municipality level (but see below models which impose matching within the same province).

of relevant municipal characteristics, including population, population density, unemployment, share of elderly people, share of adults with secondary education, and percentage of foreign residents. Average treatment effects on the treated (ATT) are then computed using a difference-in-differences estimator, where the weighted average of the refined matched control units serves as the counterfactual outcome. As an alternative specification, I use the staggered DiD estimator by Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021). Both these models estimate the effects associated with (a) the entry of a local candidate, (b) the election of a local legislator in parliament, and (c) the appointment of a local minister to the cabinet.

To isolate the effect of officeholding from the impact of candidacy, I complement the matching analyses with a close-election regression discontinuity design leveraging the single-member districts of the lower house mixed-member majoritarian elections of 1994, 1996, and 2001.⁸ The design compares municipalities whose locally born candidate narrowly won the district seat to those whose locally born candidate narrowly lost in the previous election, using the candidate’s vote-share margin over the best losing candidate as the running variable. The outcome is the change in a municipality’s turnout from the election at $t - 1$ to t . Winning a single-member district, however, does not deterministically assign the MP treatment for two reasons. First, approximately a quarter of lower house seats were allocated through the proportional tier, allowing dual candidates who lost their district race to enter parliament. Second, a municipality may be represented by a local legislator elected in a different district. Therefore, I estimate a fuzzy RDD, using victory in the district race as an instrument for the presence of a local MP. Since municipalities with a narrowly elected local candidate are always treated, non-compliance is one-sided: municipalities assigned to the control condition may still receive the treatment. With this design, the estimates identify the local average treatment effect for compliers, i.e., municipalities with a narrowly elected

8. Candidates running for the upper house are not included because of the rules of the 1993 electoral system. While the lower house had separate party lists for the proportional tier, proportional seats in the upper house were assigned to the best losing candidates in each region. Consequently, candidates who narrowly lost an upper house district race were often elected in the proportional tier, which attenuates the discontinuity in treatment assignment around the threshold.

local candidate.⁹ I compute local-linear effects with a triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, election-year fixed effects, and standard errors clustered by municipality (Calonico et al. 2017).

In the individual-level analyses, I run multilevel models with respondents nested in election years. In addition to municipal population, I control for a series of variables that constitute the classic predictors of voter turnout (Dassonneville and Kostelka 2021). These include gender, age, employment status, university degree, political interest, and closeness to a political party.

Results

Figure 2 displays the results of the municipality-level analyses. Starting from Panel *a*, the presence of a local candidate running for election significantly increases turnout. Municipalities with at least one local candidate experience higher turnout compared to matched municipalities without local candidates. The effect size is modest, as the presence of a local candidate increases turnout by 0.4–0.5 percentage points (0.13 standard deviations of the average election-to-election change in turnout). These results support H1, in line with existing findings on the mobilising effects of candidates with local roots (Fiva and Smith 2017; Górecki et al. 2022).

Notably, the effect spills over to the next election ($t + 1$). This pattern is consistent with habit formation in voting, in which the act of voting makes people accustomed to voting, even in the absence of continued treatment exposure (Coppock and Green 2016; Gerber et al. 2003). Additional support for this interpretation comes from the treatment reversal analysis (Figure A18), which shows that turnout does not decline when a municipality loses a local candidate between elections. Overall, these patterns suggest that the presence of a local candidate may produce a small but persistent increase in participation that extends beyond a single election.

9. Given that larger municipalities are likely to have multiple local candidates competing and possibly elected, the RDD sample is disproportionately composed of smaller municipalities, where I expect the visibility of local traits to be stronger. Municipalities with fewer than 25,000 inhabitants account for 78% of compliers, compared to 63% of all municipalities represented by a local MP.

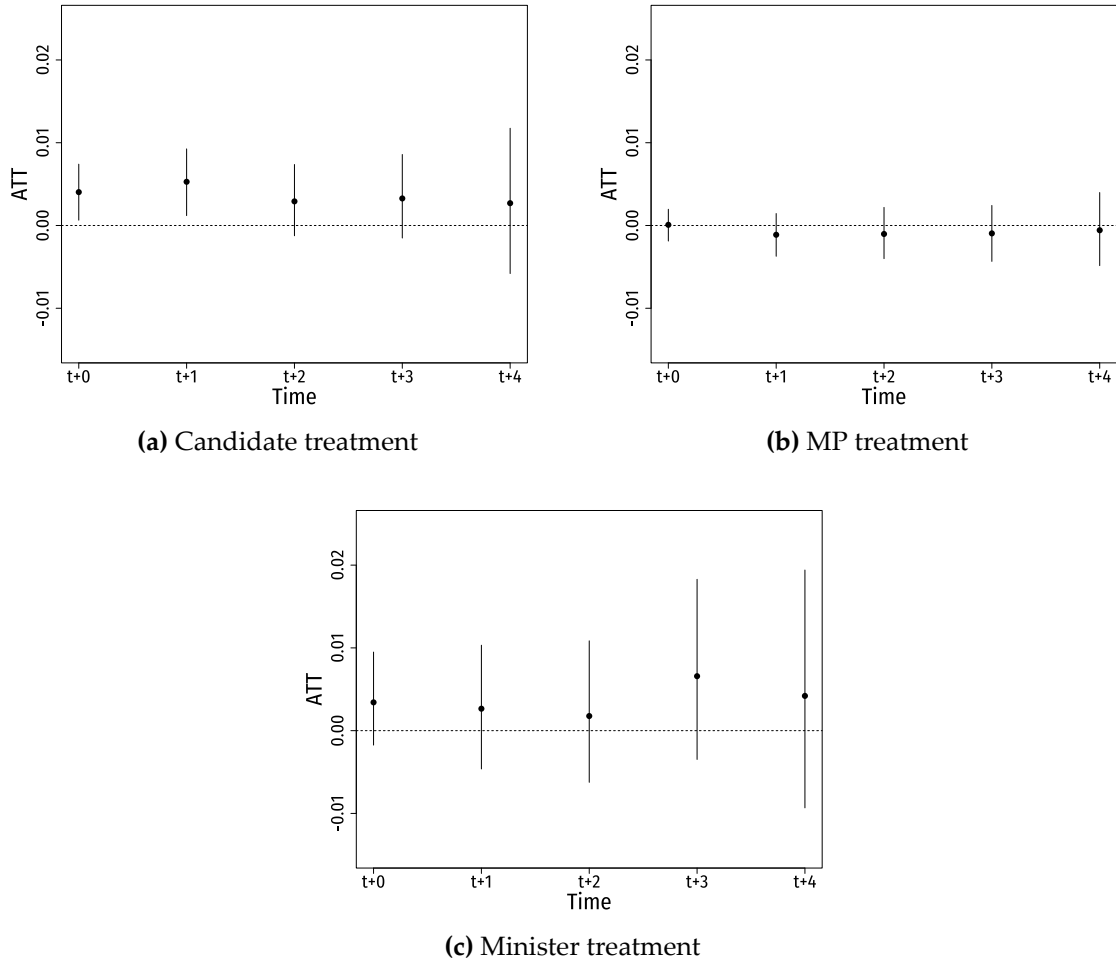


Figure 2. Effects of local politicians on turnout (95% confidence intervals)

By contrast, Panel *b* of Figure 2 shows that, consistent with H2, the election of a local MP does not increase turnout in the municipality: the estimated effect is statistically insignificant and substantively close to zero.¹⁰ These results are consistent with the null findings reported by Fiva et al. (2021) for Norway.

A potential concern with the results in Panel *b* is that the municipalities that elect a local MP are not a random subset of those that field a local candidate. Moreover, the control group in the main analyses pools municipalities that fielded a losing local candidate with those that fielded none at all. To address these concerns and isolate the effect of holding office, I leverage the majoritarian tier of the mixed-member system employed in the 1994, 1996, and 2001 lower house elections. The resulting RDD provides

10. Equivalence tests (Figure A14) indicate that effects comparable in magnitude to those estimated for local candidates can be ruled out (Lakens et al. 2018).

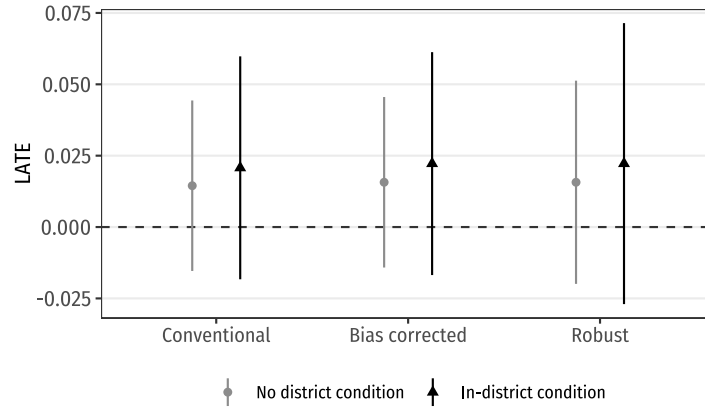


Figure 3. Effect of narrowly electing a local candidate on turnout, fuzzy RDD (95% confidence intervals)

an opportunity to test whether local incumbency contributes an additional mobilisation effect on top of a (competitive) candidacy. The results, reported in [Figure 3](#), are consistent with the evidence from the matching analyses. Municipalities whose local candidate wins, rather than loses, a single-member district race by a narrow margin (and therefore receive the MP treatment) experience a positive but statistically insignificant increase in turnout. Similar results emerge when the analysis focuses on candidates whose hometown lies inside the contested district, where local constituents could have voted for them.¹¹

Panel *c* reports the effect of local ministers on turnout. As with local MPs, the estimated effect is not statistically distinguishable from zero. Differently from the results for local MPs, however, the point estimate is larger, and equivalence tests ([Figure A14](#)) do not rule out effects comparable in magnitude to those associated with local candidates. Given the limited number of treated municipalities, this analysis has low statistical power, making the evidence for a null effect less conclusive. Nevertheless, the lack of significant effects even for a more visible and better resourced political office seems to support the argument that the mobilisation potential of local traits is primarily a campaign phenomenon.

A series of robustness tests, reported in the Appendix, corroborates the main findings. First, the results hold under different matching criteria ([Figures A2](#), [A7](#), and

11. The results are robust to different bandwidths (see [Figure A10](#)).

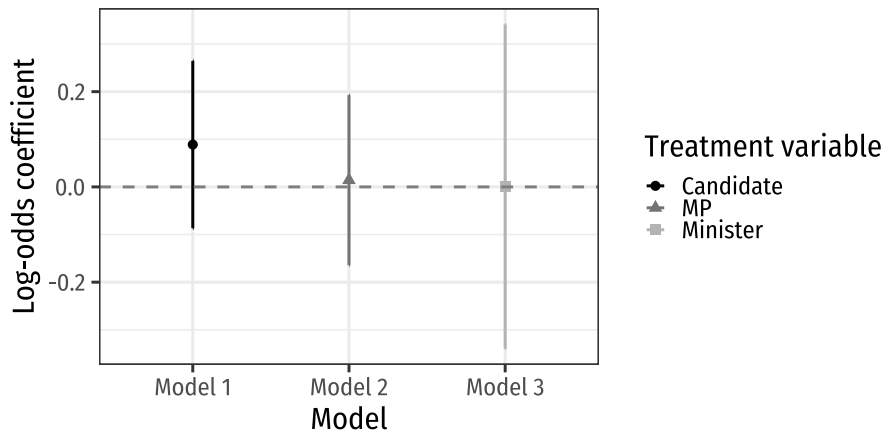


Figure 4. Correlation between local politicians and reported turnout (95% confidence intervals)

A11). Second, a staggered difference-in-differences design yields substantively similar effects across all treatments (Figures A15–A17). Third, the results remain stable when redefining treatment – for instance, by including candidates or legislators born in the same region where they compete or restricting the legislator treatment to incumbents seeking re-election. Fourth, perhaps surprisingly, effects do not vary significantly across different electoral systems. Fifth, when identification is restricted to geographically proximate units – either by matching within provinces or by explicitly modelling spatial dependence – the estimated treatment effects attenuate and often become statistically insignificant, consistent with the presence of spatial spillovers across neighbouring units. Finally, no significant effects emerge when employing an alternative measure of localness based on prior experience as mayor or councillor (see the discussion in the conclusion).

I then examine whether the aggregate-level results are mirrored in the individual-level analyses. Survey data do not allow causal identification, but I explore whether the correlational evidence is consistent with the aggregate effects. As shown in Figure 4, treatment coefficients from multilevel logistic regressions indicate null results across all treatments. In contrast to the aggregate analyses, individual-level results reveal no significant association between the presence of a local candidate and voters’ likelihood of voting.

Several reasons may account for this discrepancy. First, the individual-level analysis covers a shorter period (2001–2013 instead of 1994–2022). When aggregate analyses are restricted to the same period, the effect of local candidates similarly becomes insignificant (Figure A13). Second, self-reported turnout tends to overestimate actual turnout (Dassonneville and Kostelka 2021). While such bias is unlikely to correlate directly with the treatment variables, it reduces variation in the dependent variable and the chances of detecting treatment effects. Third, survey respondents disproportionately reside in treated municipalities, limiting variation in exposure to the treatment. Fourth, the two analyses capture different quantities of interest: the effect of the *entry* of a local candidate (aggregate models) and the association with the *presence* of a local candidate (survey models).

The survey data also allow me to assess whether the evidence is consistent with a place-based identity account. If local candidates mobilise voters by activating attachment to place, their effect should be stronger where place-based identities are more salient. I examine two implications of this expectation. The first is that place-based identities are likely to be more salient in towns and small cities, where candidates are more visible and local social networks are denser, than in larger cities. The second is that voters who are more attached to their municipality should be more responsive to local candidates. To identify these voters, I use a survey item available in the 2001 and 2006 rounds that asks respondents which territorial community they feel they belong to most – their municipality, region, Italy, Europe, or the world.

Both implications find support. Figure A19 in the Appendix shows that in smaller municipalities (below 25,000 inhabitants), the association between the presence of a local candidate and turnout is positive and significant. This pattern is also evident in the aggregate analyses, where the effect of local candidates on turnout is driven by small municipalities (Figure A6). Similarly, the presence of a local candidate in the race is positively and significantly associated with reported turnout among respondents whose primary territorial attachment is to their municipality, but not among those who feel attached to higher-level entities (Figure A20).

Finally, the survey data allow me to explore more directly two of the channels through which local politicians are related to turnout: social networks and political efficacy. Consistent with the argument that candidates can mobilise voters by drawing on denser local networks and campaigning more intensively in their home areas (Fiva and Smith 2017), respondents living in a candidate's home municipality are significantly more likely to report having been contacted during the campaign (Figure A21). Representation by a local legislator or minister, by contrast, should increase voters' sense of political efficacy. Yet the treatments are not associated with higher efficacy (Figure A22). Again, this additional evidence supports the interpretation of the effects of local roots as a campaign rather than a representational phenomenon.

Conclusion

This article explores whether politicians' local traits mobilise voters. Local roots may mobilise voters by making candidates more salient when they appear on the ballot, but they may also matter after the election if voters become more engaged when their community is represented by an in-group member. Using data from Italian elections, I find that local candidates have a significant, albeit modest, effect on electoral participation. In municipalities where a hometown candidate contested a parliamentary seat, turnout was higher than in comparable municipalities without a local candidate. Supporting findings from earlier studies (Fiva and Smith 2017; Panagopoulos et al. 2017), this suggests that shared place-based identities mobilise additional voters.

However, the mobilisation effect appears limited to election campaigns: once elected to parliament or appointed as ministers, local incumbents do not increase voter participation at the following election. One possible explanation is that descriptive localism (the presence of a local candidate on the ballot) matters more for turnout than behavioural localism in office (see also Nyholt 2024). A plausible alternative reading of these asymmetric results is that candidates can personalise and localise their appeals during the campaign, whereas MPs and ministers have fewer incentives to prioritise

local interests once in office. Consistent with this, evidence from Czechia indicates that MPs elected on the basis of strong local support later become highly loyal to the party line, shifting their focus from the constituency to the party leadership (Smrek 2023).

In conclusion, the findings for local candidates indicate that place-based identities are important in shaping voters' behaviour, suggesting that geographically balanced candidate lists can increase electoral participation. As recent research shows that mixed-member electoral systems produce more geographically representative legislatures (Carella and Eggers 2024), further studies exploring the geographical distribution of candidates under different institutional arrangements could shed light on the connection between electoral systems and turnout. Moreover, a limitation of the current study relates to the operationalisation of localness, which relies on politicians' birthplaces due to the lack of systematic data on politicians' place of residence in the Italian context. Yet analyses in [Appendix D](#) show that models which use prior local political experience to identify localness fail to produce significant effects even in the candidate treatment models. This suggests that fixed identities based on ascriptive traits might be more consequential in mobilising voters, at least as far as local traits are concerned.

References

- Angelucci, D., L. Carrieri and M. Improta (2024). ‘‘No Participation Without Representation’: The Impact of Descriptive and Substantive Representation on the Age-Related Turnout Gap’. *Political Studies*: 00323217241229316.
- Barreto, M. A. (2007). ‘ÍSí Se Puede! Latino Candidates and the Mobilization of Latino Voters’. *American Political Science Review*, 101(3): 425–441.
- Bobo, L. and F.D. Gilliam (1990). ‘Race, Sociopolitical Participation, and Black Empowerment’. *American Political Science Review*, 84(2): 377–393.
- Callaway, B. and P.H.C. Sant’Anna (2021). ‘Difference-in-Differences with Multiple Time Periods’. *Journal of Econometrics*. Themed Issue: Treatment Effect 1 225(2): 200–230.
- Calonico, S., M.D. Cattaneo, M.H. Farrell and R. Titiunik (2017). ‘Rdrobust: Software for Regression-discontinuity Designs’. *The Stata Journal*, 17(2): 372–404.
- Campbell, D.E. and C. Wolbrecht (2006). ‘See Jane Run: Women Politicians as Role Models for Adolescents’. *The Journal of Politics*, 68(2): 233–247.
- Campbell, R., P. Cowley, N. Vivyan and M. Wagner (2019). ‘Why Friends and Neighbors? Explaining the Electoral Appeal of Local Roots’. *The Journal of Politics*, 81(3): 937–951.
- Carella, L. and A. Eggers (2024). ‘Electoral Systems and Geographic Representation’. *British Journal of Political Science*, 54(1): 40–68.
- Carey, J.M. and M.S. Shugart (1995). ‘Incentives to Cultivate a Personal Vote: A Rank Ordering of Electoral Formulas’. *Electoral Studies*, 14(4): 417–439.
- Catalinac, A., B. Bueno de Mesquita and A. Smith (2020). ‘A Tournament Theory of Pork Barrel Politics: The Case of Japan’. *Comparative Political Studies*, 53(10-11): 1619–1655.
- Chen, J. (2013). ‘Voter Partisanship and the Effect of Distributive Spending on Political Participation’. *American Journal of Political Science*, 57(1): 200–217.

- Coppock, A. and D.P. Green (2016). 'Is Voting Habit Forming? New Evidence from Experiments and Regression Discontinuities'. *American Journal of Political Science*, 60(4): 1044–1062.
- Dassonneville, R. and F. Kostelka (2021). 'The Cultural Sources of the Gender Gap in Voter Turnout'. *British Journal of Political Science*, 51(3): 1040–1061.
- Decadri, S. (2021). "'What Have You Done for Me Lately?' Re-thinking Local Representation'. *Electoral Studies*, 74: 102417.
- Fiva, J. H. and A. H. Halse (2016). 'Local Favoritism in At-Large Proportional Representation Systems'. *Journal of Public Economics*, 143: 15–26.
- Fiva, J. H., A. H. Halse and D. M. Smith (2021). 'Local Representation and Voter Mobilization in Closed-list Proportional Representation Systems'. *Quarterly Journal of Political Science*, 16(2): 185–213.
- Fiva, J. H. and D. M. Smith (2017). 'Local Candidates and Voter Mobilization: Evidence from Historical Two-Round Elections in Norway'. *Electoral Studies*, 45: 130–140.
- Gagliarducci, S., T. Nannicini and P. Naticchioni (2011). 'Electoral Rules and Politicians' Behavior: A Micro Test'. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 3(3): 144–174.
- Geese, L. (2023). 'Does Descriptive Representation Narrow the Immigrant Gap in Turnout? A Comparative Study across 11 Western European Democracies'. *Political Studies*, 71(4): 1277–1297.
- Gerber, A. S., D. P. Green and R. Shachar (2003). 'Voting May Be Habit-Forming: Evidence from a Randomized Field Experiment'. *American Journal of Political Science*, 47(3): 540–550.
- Golden, M. (2003). 'Electoral Connections: The Effects of the Personal Vote on Political Patronage, Bureaucracy and Legislation in Postwar Italy'. *British Journal of Political Science*, 33(2): 189–212.
- Golden, M. A. and L. Picci (2008). 'Pork-Barrel Politics in Postwar Italy, 1953–94'. *American Journal of Political Science*, 52(2): 268–289.

- Górecki, M. A., S. Bartnicki and M. Alimowski (2022). 'Local Voting at Local Elections Revisited: 'Friends and Neighbors Voting' at Mayoral Elections in Rural Poland'. *Political Geography*, 94: 102559.
- Griffin, J. D. and M. Keane (2006). 'Descriptive Representation and the Composition of African American Turnout'. *American Journal of Political Science*, 50(4): 998–1012.
- Horiuchi, Y., D. M. Smith and T. Yamamoto (2020). 'Identifying Voter Preferences for Politicians' Personal Attributes: A Conjoint Experiment in Japan'. *Political Science Research and Methods*, 8(1): 75–91.
- Huwyler, O., N. Giger, S. Bailer, T. Turner-Zwinkels and S. Heller (2025). 'Constituency References in Social Media: MPs' Usage and Voters' Reaction'. *European Journal of Political Research*, 64(4): 1974–1998.
- Imai, K., I. S. Kim and E. H. Wang (2023). 'Matching Methods for Causal Inference with Time-Series Cross-Sectional Data'. *American Journal of Political Science*, 67(3): 587–605.
- Key, V. O. (1949). *Southern Politics*. New York: Knopf.
- Kovarek, D. (2022). 'Distributive Politics as Behavioral Localism: Evidence from a Vignette Experiment in Hungary'. *Research & Politics*, 9(3): 20531680221122279.
- Lakens, D., A. M. Scheel and P. M. Isager (2018). 'Equivalence Testing for Psychological Research: A Tutorial'. *Advances in Methods and Practices in Psychological Science*, 1(2): 259–269.
- Magee, J. C. and P. K. Smith (2013). 'The Social Distance Theory of Power'. *Personality and Social Psychology Review*, 17(2): 158–186.
- Martin, S. (2016). 'Policy, Office and Votes: The Electoral Value of Ministerial Office'. *British Journal of Political Science*, 46(2): 281–296.
- Meredith, M. (2013). 'Exploiting Friends-and-Neighbors to Estimate Coattail Effects'. *American Political Science Review*, 107(4): 742–765.
- Nyholt, N. (2024). 'Why Do Voters Prefer Local Candidates? Evidence from a Danish Conjoint Survey Experiment'. *Political Behavior*, 46(4): 2313–2332.

- Panagopoulos, C. and K. Bailey (2020). “‘Friends-and-Neighbors’ Mobilization: A Field Experimental Replication and Extension’. *Journal of Experimental Political Science*, 7(1): 13–26.
- Panagopoulos, C., J. E. Leighley and B. T. Hamel (2017). ‘Are Voters Mobilized by a ‘Friend-and-Neighbor’ on the Ballot? Evidence from a Field Experiment’. *Political Behavior*, 39(4): 865–882.
- Rice, T. W. and A. A. Macht (1987). ‘The Hometown Advantage: Mobilization or Conversion?’ *Political Behavior*, 9(3): 257–262.
- Rocha, R. R., C. J. Tolbert, D. C. Bowen and C. J. Clark (2010). ‘Race and Turnout: Does Descriptive Representation in State Legislatures Increase Minority Voting?’ *Political Research Quarterly*, 63(4): 890–907.
- Russo, F. (2011). ‘The Constituency as a Focus of Representation: Studying the Italian Case Through the Analysis of Parliamentary Questions’. *The Journal of Legislative Studies*, 17(3): 290–301.
- Schulte-Cloos, J. and P. C. Bauer (2021). ‘Local Candidates, Place-Based Identities, and Electoral Success’. *Political Behavior*.
- Segura, G. M. and S. Bowler (2005). *Diversity in Democracy: Minority Representation in the United States*. Charlottesville: University of Virginia Press. ISBN: 978-0-8139-2337-6.
- Shugart, M. S., M. E. Valdini and K. Suominen (2005). ‘Looking for Locals: Voter Information Demands and Personal Vote-Earning Attributes of Legislators under Proportional Representation’. *American Journal of Political Science*, 49(2): 437–449.
- Smrek, M. (2023). ‘Mavericks or Loyalists? Popular Ballot Jumpers and Party Discipline in the Flexible-List PR Context’. *Political Research Quarterly*, 76(1): 323–336.
- Suiter, J. and E. O’Malley (2014). ‘Yes, Minister: The Impact of Decision-making Rules on Geographically Targeted Particularistic Spending’. *Parliamentary Affairs*, 67(4): 935–954.
- Tavits, M. (2010). ‘Effect of Local Ties On Electoral Success and Parliamentary Behaviour: The Case of Estonia’. *Party Politics*, 16(2): 215–235.

- Uhlaner, C.J. (2012). 'Potentiality and Representation: The Link between Descriptive Representation and Participation in the United States'. *Politics & Gender*, 8(4): 535–541.
- Van Aelst, P., B. Maddens, J. Noppe and S. Fiers (2008). 'Politicians in the News: Media or Party Logic?: Media Attention and Electoral Success in the Belgian Election Campaign of 2003'. *European Journal of Communication*, 23(2): 193–210.
- Velimsky, J. A., S. Block, M. Gross and D. Nyhuis (2024). 'Probing the Effect of Candidate Localness in Low-Information Elections: Evidence from the German Local Level'. *Political Studies*, 72(3): 1090–1111.
- Washington, E. (2006). 'How Black Candidates Affect Voter Turnout'. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 121(3): 973–998.
- Widmer, P. and N. Zurlinden (2022). 'Ministers Engage in Favoritism Too'. *Journal of Public Economics*, 213: 104707.
- Zittel, T., D. Nyhuis and M. Baumann (2019). 'Geographic Representation in Party-Dominated Legislatures: A Quantitative Text Analysis of Parliamentary Questions in the German Bundestag'. *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, 44(4): 681–711.

Online Appendix for
Politicians with Local Roots and Voter Turnout

Contents

A	Data sources	A2
B	Descriptive statistics	A4
C	Full models	A7
D	Robustness tests	A8
E	Additional tests	A20
E.1	Treatment reversal	A20
E.2	Municipality size	A21
E.3	Local attachment	A21
E.4	Contacts with politicians	A22
E.5	Political efficacy	A22
E.6	Results split by electoral system	A23

A Data sources

Study 1

The dataset is composed of three main parts: (a) turnout data, (b) data on candidates, MPs, and ministers, and (c) socioeconomic variables.

Turnout

Municipality-level election results are sourced from the open data of the Italian Ministry of Interior (<https://elezionistorico.interno.gov.it/eligendo/opendata.php>).

Politicians

Data on parliamentary candidates (for whom birthplaces are available since 1992) are drawn from the open data portal of the Italian Ministry of Interior (<https://elezionistorico.interno.gov.it/eligendo/opendata.php>). Data on legislators and cabinet members are collected from the open data portals of the lower and the upper house (<https://dati.camera.it/> and <https://dati.senato.it/sito/home>, respectively). For the definition of localness based on previous political experience at the municipal level, I employ data from the archive of elected public administrators (from 1986 onwards; <http://amministratori.interno.it/>).

Socioeconomic variables

Socioeconomic indicators at the municipal level were collected from the national statistical office (ISTAT) that provides census data from 1951 to 2011 at ten-year intervals (<http://ottomilacensus.istat.it/download-dati/>). For intercensal years, data are geometrically interpolated assuming a constant growth rate. Since 2012, I rely on yearly ISTAT data (<http://demo.istat.it>).

Study 2

Data on voters' reported turnout and sociodemographic variables are drawn from the Italian National Election Studies (ITANES; <https://www.itanes.it/category/data-portal/>).

B Descriptive statistics

Study 2

Table A1. Summary statistics, individual-level data

Variable	N	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Turnout (reported)	10985	0.92	0.28	0	1
Candidate treat.	9707	0.69	0.46	0	1
MP treat.	9707	0.42	0.49	0	1
Minister treat.	9707	0.15	0.36	0	1
Female	11719	0.51	0.5	0	1
Age	11719	48	17	18	95
University degree	11719	0.11	0.32	0	1
Unemployed	11719	0.042	0.2	0	1
Political interest (1–4)	11690				
... 1	1616	14%			
... 2	3581	31%			
... 3	4378	37%			
... 4	2115	18%			
Party closeness	11242	0.58	0.49	0	1

Localness: birthplace and residence

To assess the validity of using birthplaces as indicators of localness, I collected data on the place of residence of lower house MPs. Residence information is self-reported and available on the house website (<https://www.camera.it/>) for a subset of MPs elected in the last two legislative terms: 654 MPs in the 18th term and 149 in the 19th term. In this sample, 39% of legislators resided in their birthplaces. Among those living in a different municipality, the median distance between birthplace and current residence is 30 km (mean = 133 km), indicating that most legislators remain geographically close to their birthplace. As shown in [Figure A1](#), the distribution of distances is strongly right-skewed, with the vast majority of observations clustered below 100 km.

Table A2. MPs' residence relative to their birthplace

Term	18		19	
	N	Percent	N	Percent
Residence	654		149	
= to birthplace	263	40%	49	33%
≠ to birthplace	391	60%	100	67%

Table A3. Distance between MPs' birthplace and current residence

Variable	N	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Pctl. 25	Pctl. 50	Pctl. 75	Max
Distance (km)	473	133	212	1.2	12	30	175	1119

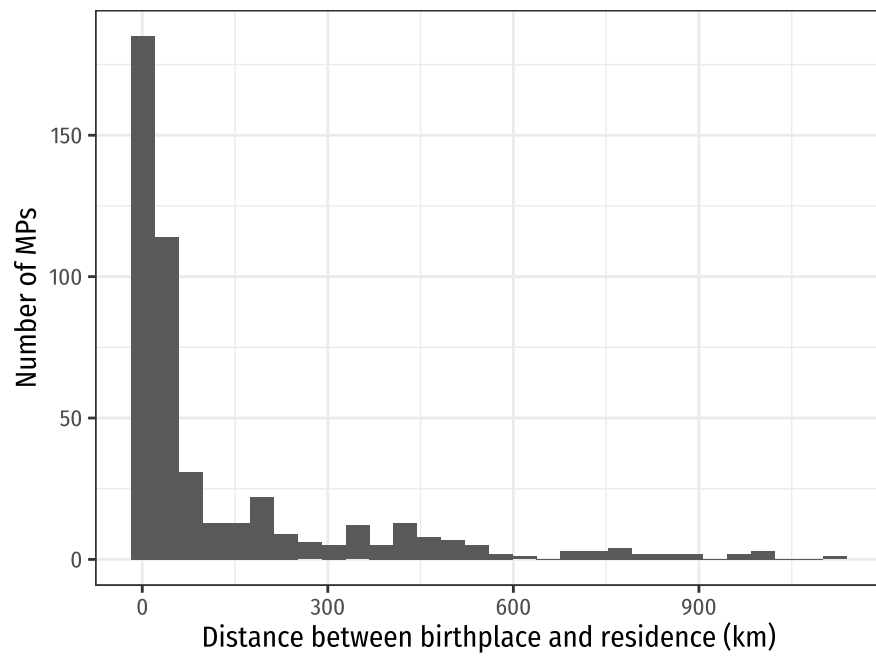


Figure A1. Distribution of distance between MPs' birthplace and current residence

C Full models

Table A4. Turnout, individual-level determinants

	Model 1a	Model 1	Model 2a	Turnout Model 2	Model 3a	Model 3	Model 4
Cand. treatment	0.109 (0.082)	0.090 (0.089)					0.114 (0.105)
MP treatment			0.041 (0.078)	0.011 (0.091)			−0.054 (0.109)
Minister treatment					−0.022 (0.107)	−0.032 (0.173)	−0.170 (0.130)
Female		0.074 (0.083)		0.073 (0.083)		0.073 (0.083)	0.074 (0.083)
Age (stand.)		−0.071*** (0.021)		−0.071*** (0.021)		−0.071*** (0.021)	−0.071*** (0.021)
University deg.		0.306* (0.162)		0.312* (0.162)		0.314* (0.162)	0.310* (0.163)
Unemployed		−0.282* (0.166)		−0.280* (0.166)		−0.279* (0.166)	−0.276* (0.166)
Pol. interest		0.453*** (0.055)		0.453*** (0.055)		0.453*** (0.055)	0.452*** (0.055)
Party closeness		0.987*** (0.089)		0.986*** (0.089)		0.986*** (0.089)	0.983*** (0.089)
Population		−0.083** (0.042)		−0.074* (0.045)		−0.063 (0.061)	
Constant	2.323*** (0.209)	0.938*** (0.273)	2.381*** (0.203)	0.996*** (0.268)	2.402*** (0.202)	1.005*** (0.266)	0.974*** (0.272)
N	9036	8719	9036	8719	9036	8719	8719
Log Likelihood	−2556.104	−2269.039	−2556.842	−2269.532	−2556.959	−2269.521	−2269.449
AIC	5118.207	4558.079	5119.683	4559.064	5119.917	4559.043	4560.899
BIC	5139.534	4628.811	5141.010	4629.796	5141.244	4629.775	4638.705

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

D Robustness tests

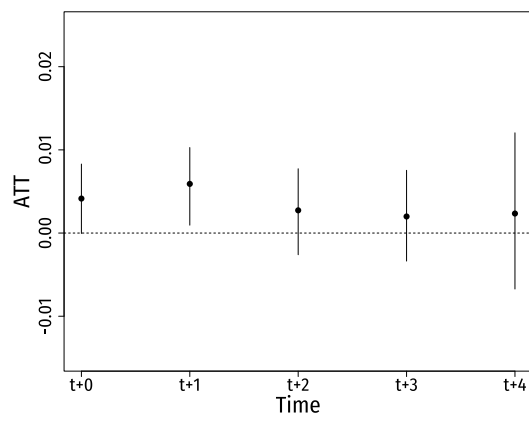
For the matching models, I perform two sets of additional tests. The first varies the specification of the matching estimator (Figure A2, Figure A7, and Figure A11). Specifically, I (a) increase the number of lags used to match units (from one in the main specification to two), (b) expand the matched set size (from 5 to 10 units), (c) employ propensity score matching instead of Mahalanobis distance, and (d) restrict matched units to the same province. Results remain substantively unchanged across the first three tests. By contrast, when matching is restricted within provinces, the effect of the candidate treatment becomes insignificant and approaches zero (Figure A2, panel d). Given the geographical proximity of municipalities in a province, I interpret this as evidence of spillover effects, whereby neighbouring municipalities are indirectly exposed to treatment. This is consistent with previous experimental evidence (Panagopoulos and Bailey 2020). Replicating the analyses at the provincial (rather than municipal) level was not feasible due to the very limited number of non-treated units.

To further investigate the presence of spatial dependence, I estimate spatial models. To the best of my knowledge, spatial extensions of matching or difference-in-differences estimators are not currently implemented in R. Therefore, I rely on two-way fixed effects (TWFE) DiD specifications with staggered treatment adoption. While TWFE estimators are known to produce biased estimates of average treatment effects under treatment heterogeneity, my goal here is not causal inference, but rather to examine the spatial dependence in the data. Within each election, turnout exhibits strong spatial autocorrelation. Regressing turnout on the candidate treatment in a spatial lag framework yields estimates of the spatial autoregressive parameter ρ of approximately 0.9, indicating substantial outcome interdependence across neighbouring municipalities. Figures A3 and A4 display the estimated treatment effect in TWFE spatial lag and spatial error models. Respectively, they model spatial dependency in the outcome and in the residuals. Given the computational demands of these models, I was not able to run them on the full sample of all municipalities. I conduct the analysis on a series of subsamples corresponding to the 2017 electoral constituencies (*circoscrizioni*), which

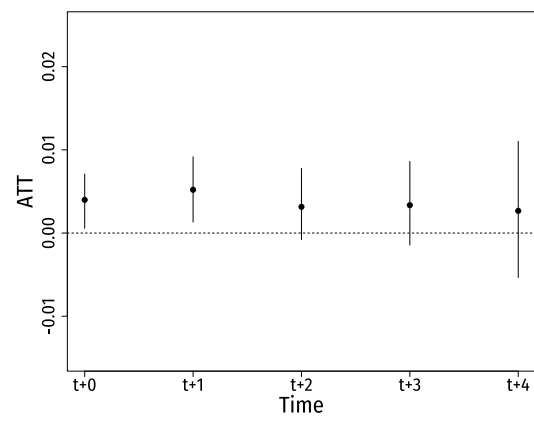
roughly align with regions (with multiple constituencies in larger regions). This choice is motivated by computational considerations, as it yields a tractable number of units per sample, and is not driven by expectations about heterogeneity across constituencies. As the results show, across most constituencies, the estimated coefficient on the candidate treatment is no longer statistically significant once spatial dependence is accounted for. I interpret this pattern as consistent with the presence of spillover effects across neighbouring municipalities.

The second set of tests varies the definition of treatment. For the candidate treatment (Figure A5), I test three alternative definitions: (a) municipalities are treated if a local candidate is running within the same region, (b) treatment is assigned only when lower-house candidates are present, and (c) localness is defined in terms of prior municipal experience (as mayor or councillor). Regional and lower-house candidate treatment ATTs are similar to the effects of the main models, although marginally insignificant likely due to power. Conversely, no effect is found when using the alternative definition of localness. This suggests that, in voters' eyes, ascriptive biographical traits such as birthplace might matter more than political experience.

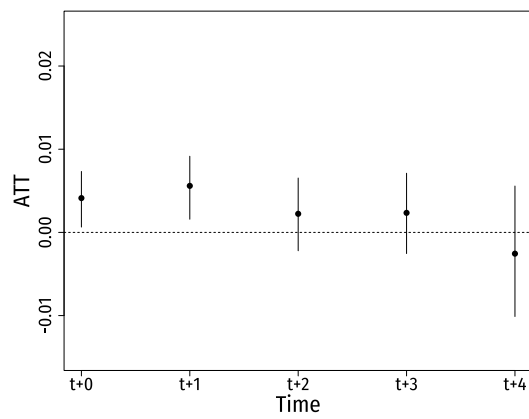
For the MP treatment (Figure A8), I apply the same alternative definitions and, additionally, require that incumbent MPs are re-running at the next election. In all cases, the effects remain insignificant. Finally, for the minister treatment (Figure A12), I consider alternative specifications based on junior ministerial roles, portfolio (i.e., high-salience) ministries, and the alternative definition of localness. Once again, results remain consistently insignificant across all models.



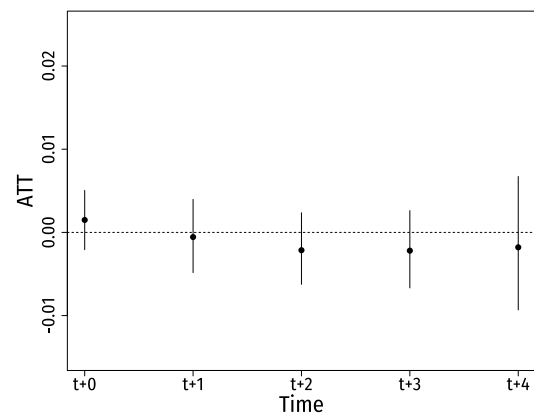
(a) 2 lags



(b) 10 units in the matched set



(c) Propensity score matching



(d) Same *circoscrizione*

Figure A2. Robustness of candidate treatment results (95% confidence intervals)

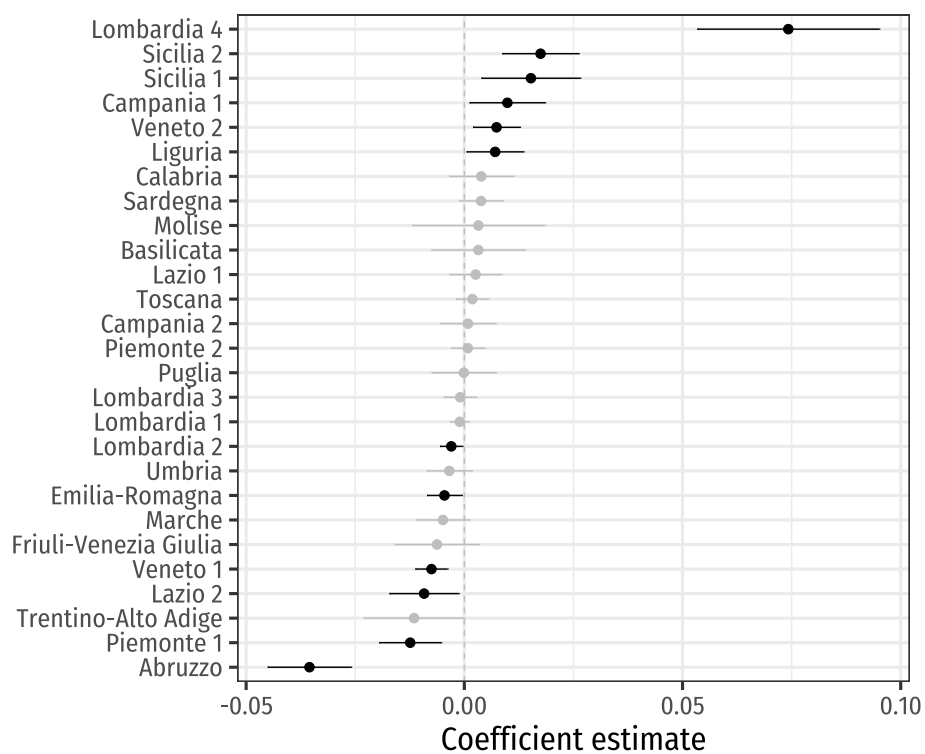


Figure A3. Effect of local candidates on turnout, spatial lag models (95% confidence intervals)

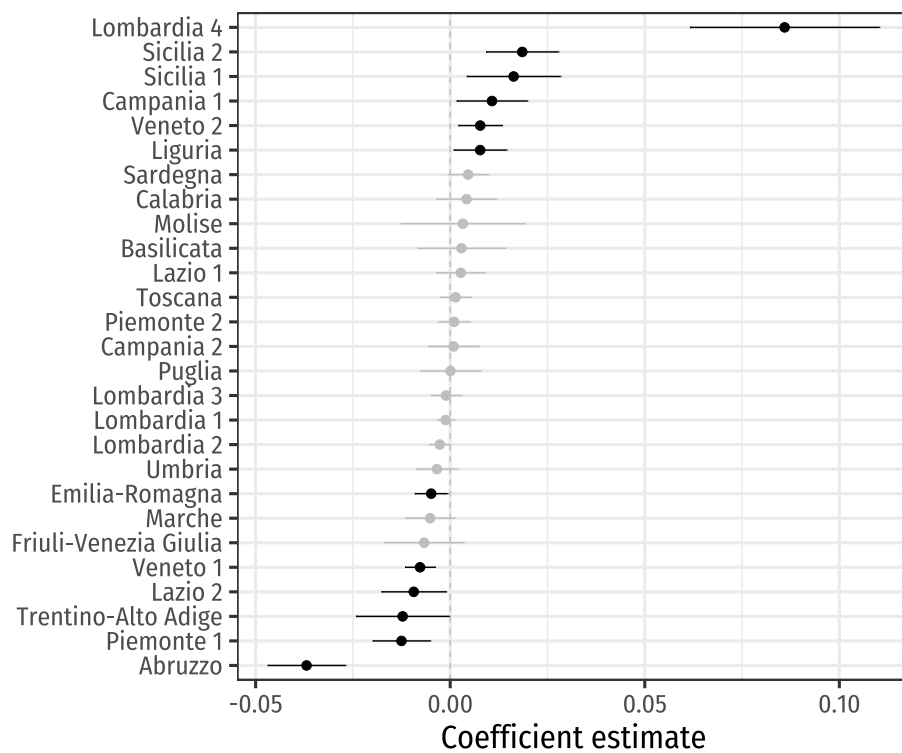
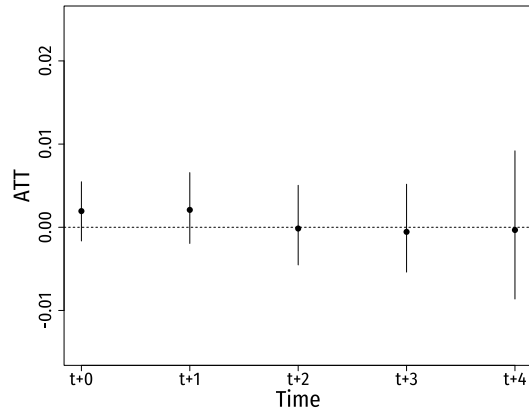
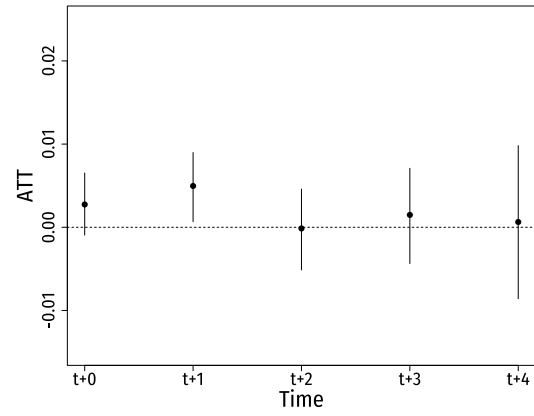


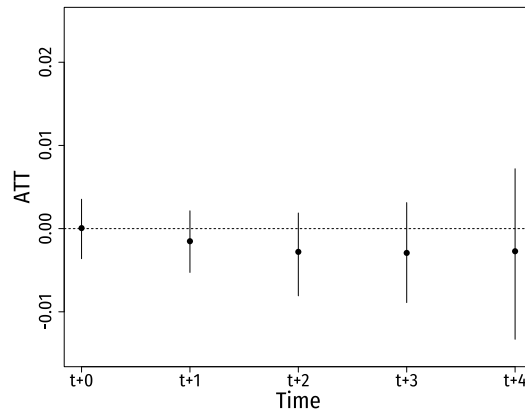
Figure A4. Effect of local candidates on turnout, spatial error models (95% confidence intervals)



(a) Region

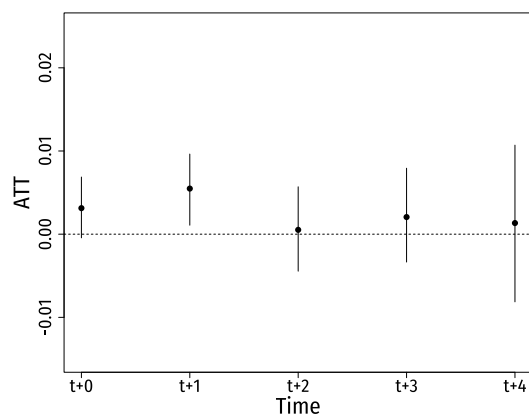


(b) Only *Camera dei Deputati*

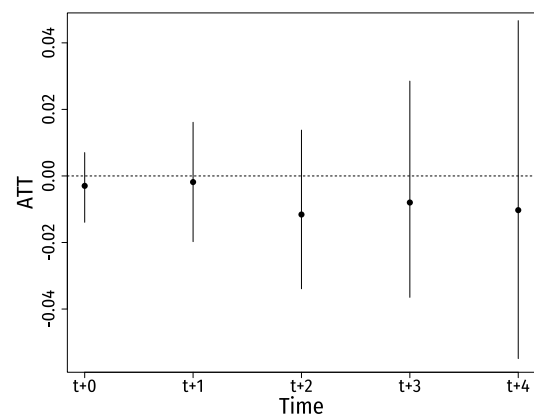


(c) Local experience

Figure A5. Alternative candidate treatment results (95% confidence intervals)

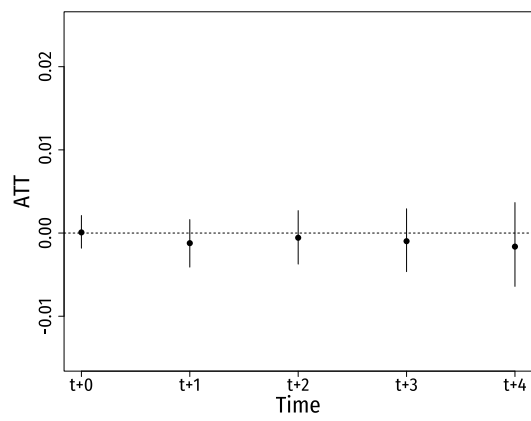


(a) Small municipalities

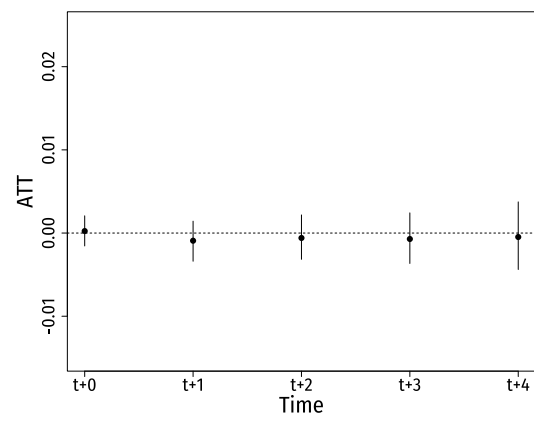


(b) Large municipalities

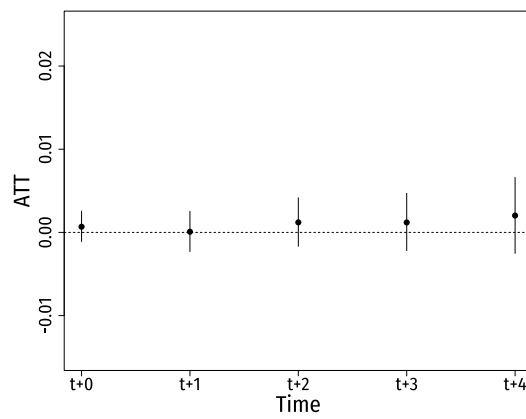
Figure A6. Candidate treatment results by municipal size (95% confidence intervals)



(a) 2 lags

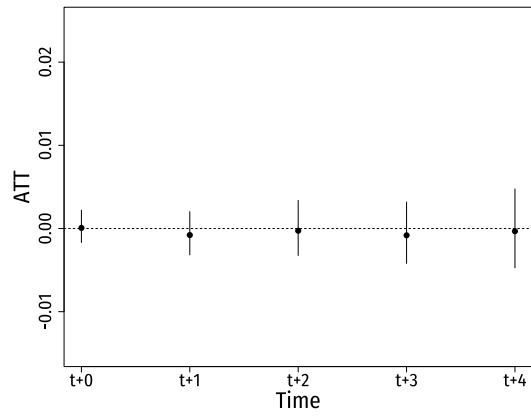


(b) 10 units in the matched set

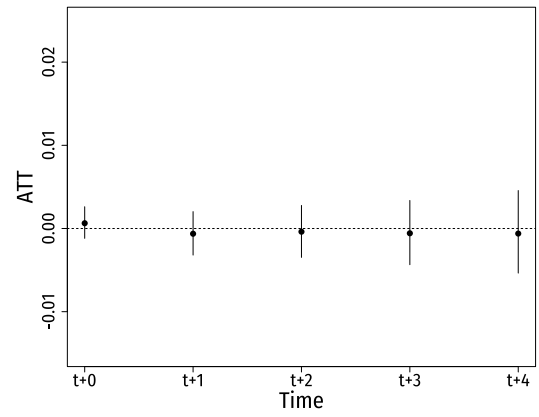


(c) Propensity score matching

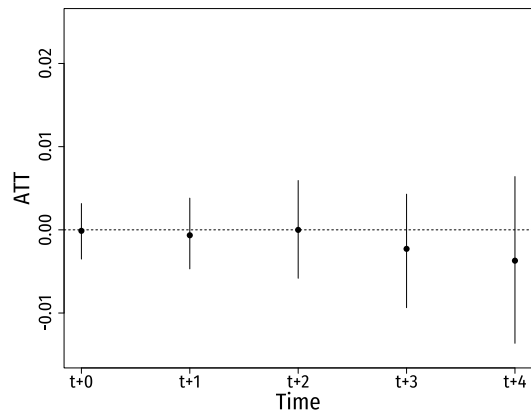
Figure A7. Robustness of MP treatment results (95% confidence intervals)



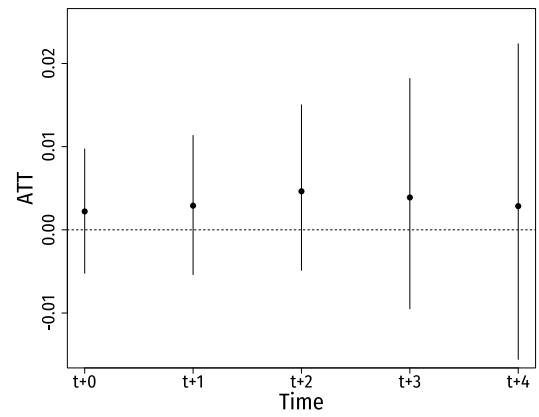
(a) Region



(b) Only Camera dei Deputati

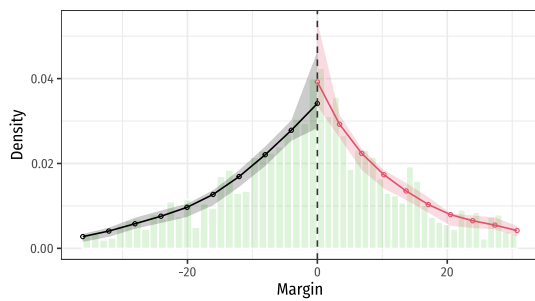


(c) Local experience

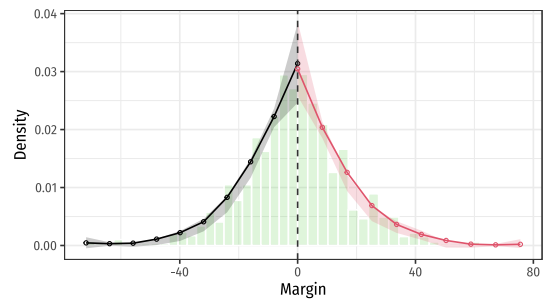


(d) Incumbents re-running

Figure A8. Alternative MP treatment results (95% confidence intervals)

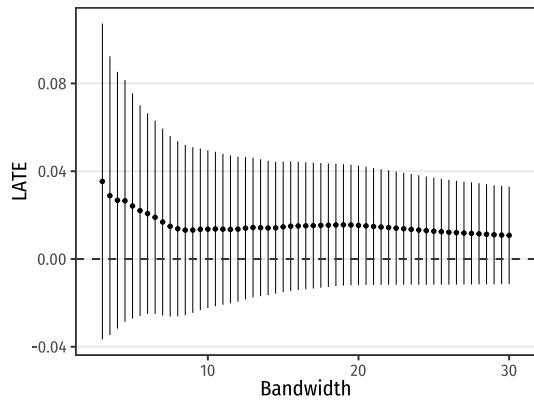


(a) No district condition

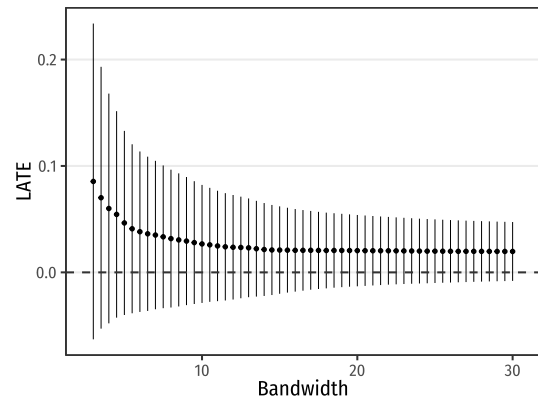


(b) In-district condition

Figure A9. McCrary density test around the RDD threshold

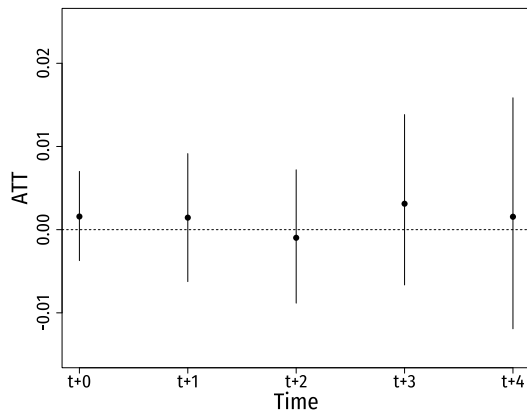


(a) No district condition

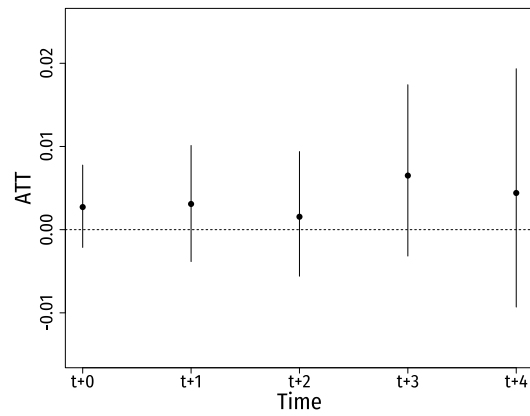


(b) In-district condition

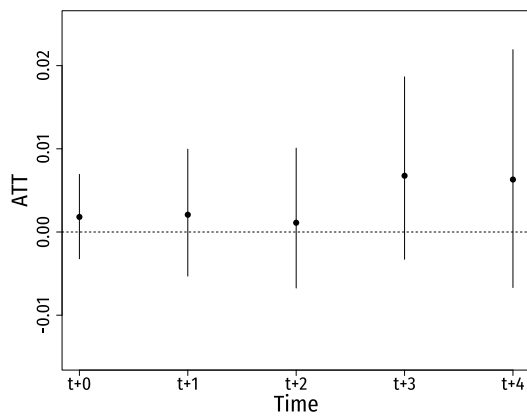
Figure A10. LATEs of MP treatment for different bandwidth specifications (95% confidence intervals)



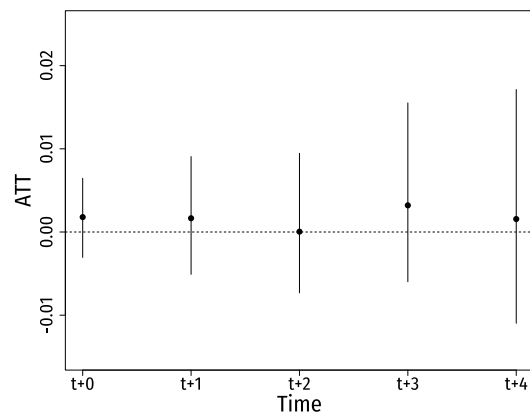
(a) 2 lags



(b) 10 units in the matched set

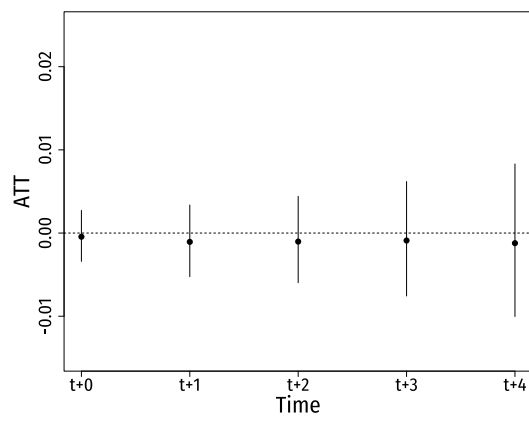


(c) Propensity score matching

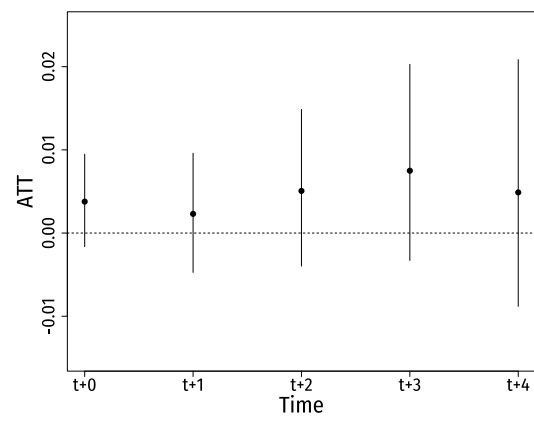


(d) Same *circoscrizione*

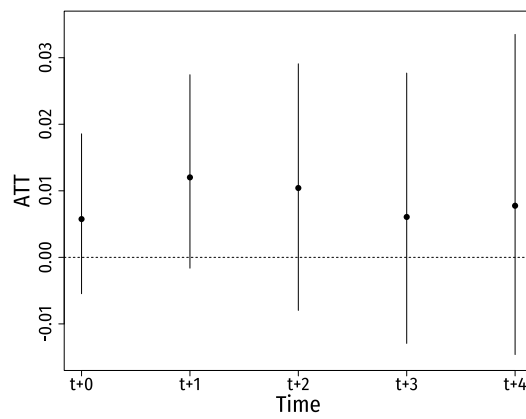
Figure A11. Robustness of minister treatment results (95% confidence intervals)



(a) Junior minister



(b) Portfolio minister



(c) Local experience

Figure A12. Alternative minister treatment results (95% confidence intervals)

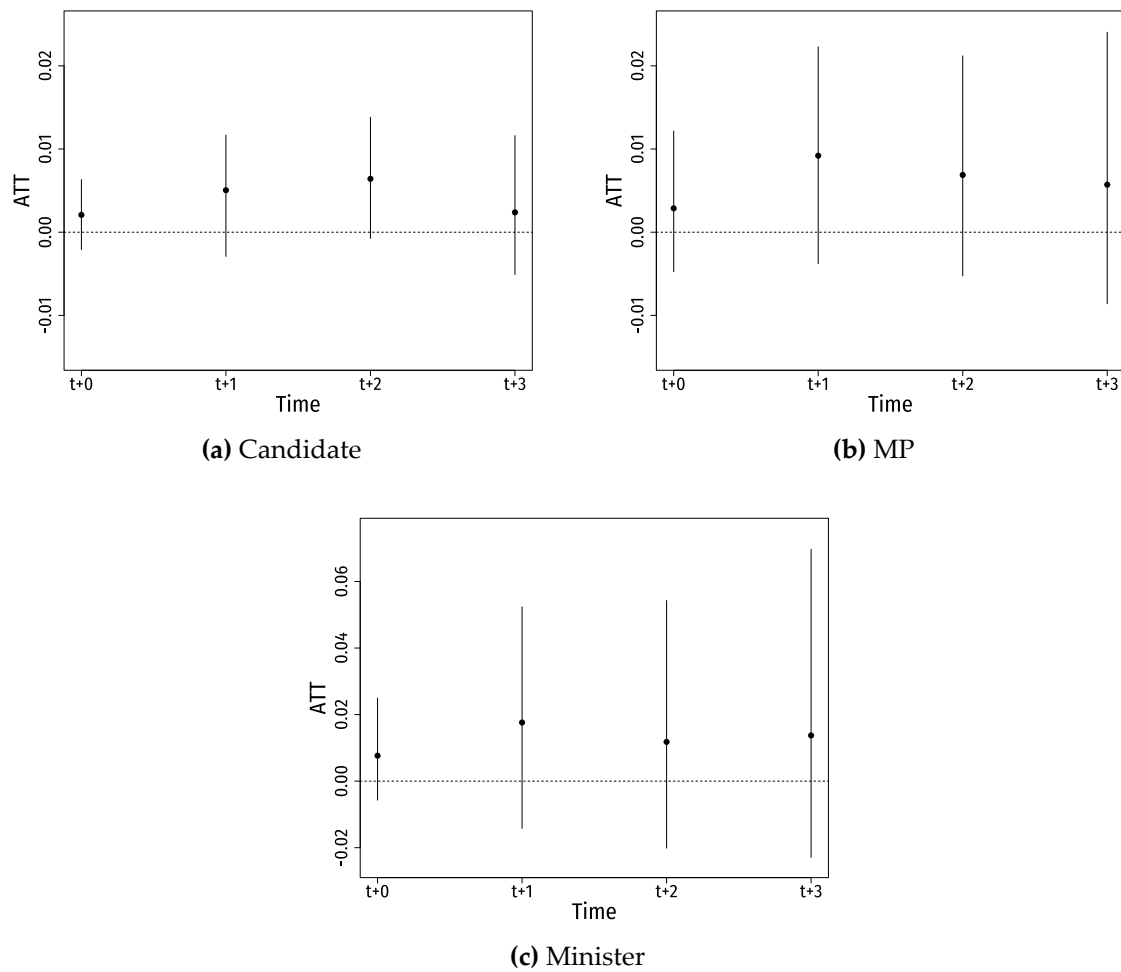


Figure A13. Treatment effects using survey data timeframe (95% confidence intervals)

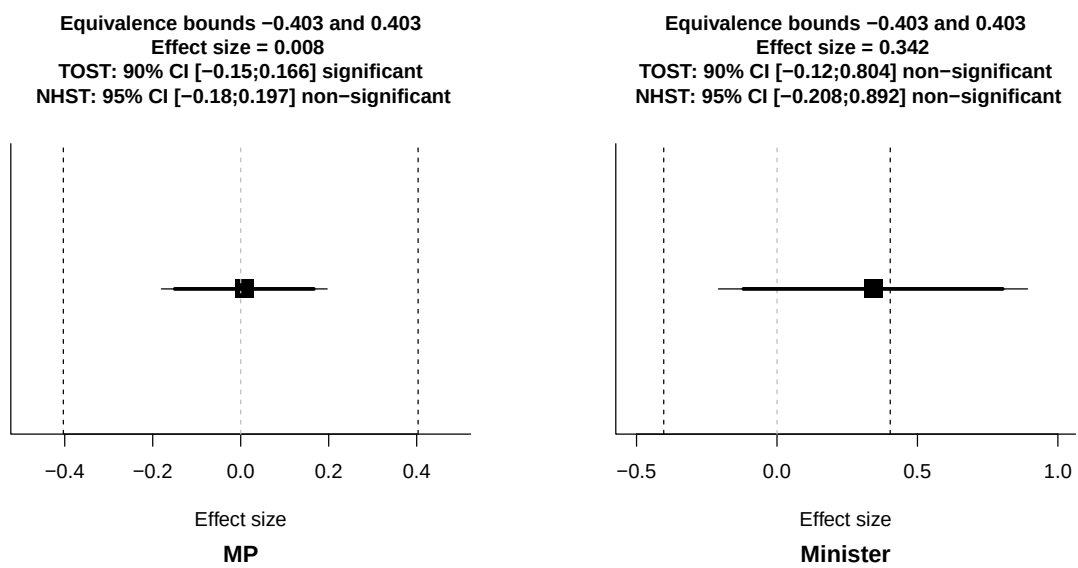


Figure A14. Equivalence tests (TOST) for MP and minister treatment

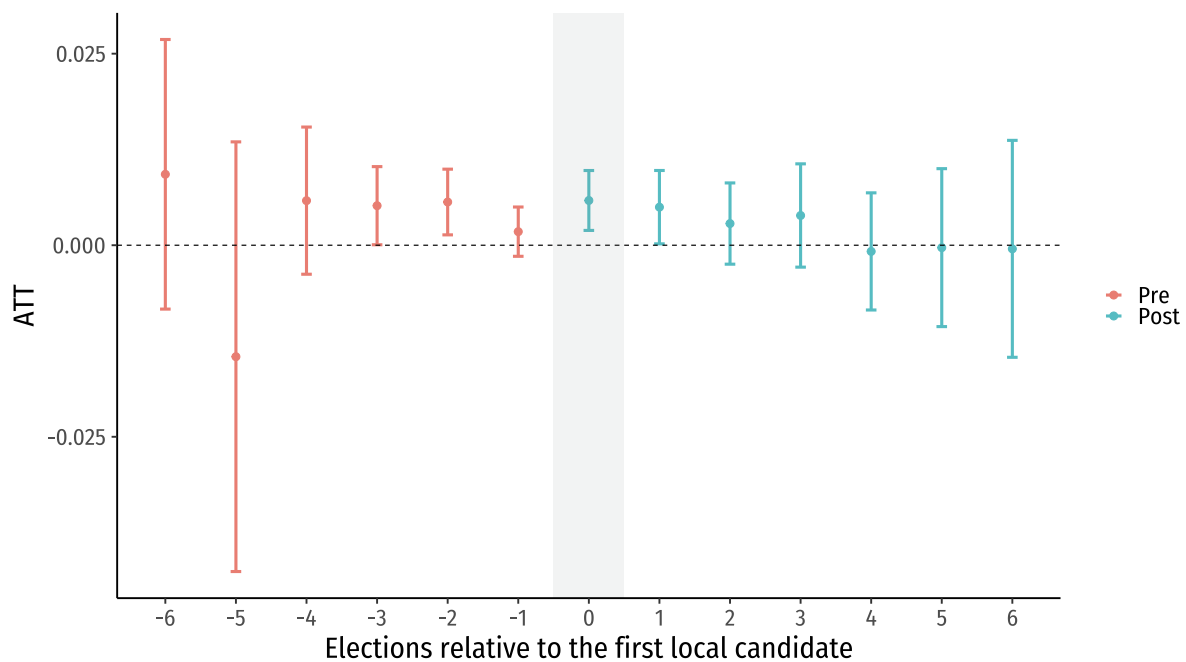


Figure A15. Effect of local candidates on turnout, staggered DiD (95% confidence intervals)

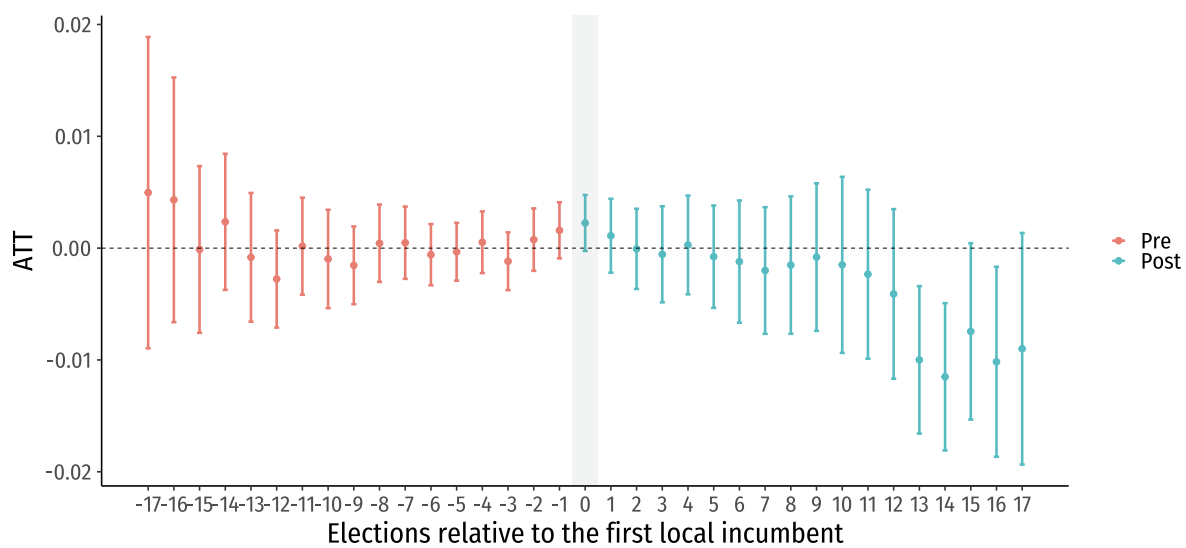


Figure A16. Effect of local MPs on turnout, staggered DiD (95% confidence intervals)

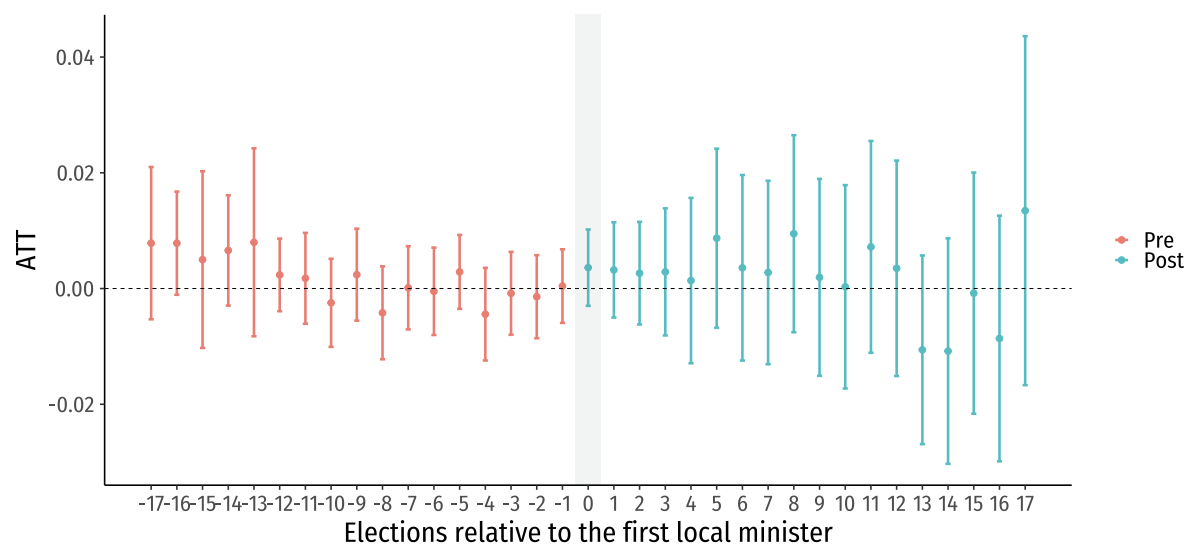


Figure A17. Effect of local ministers on turnout, staggered DiD (95% confidence intervals)

E Additional tests

E.1 Treatment reversal

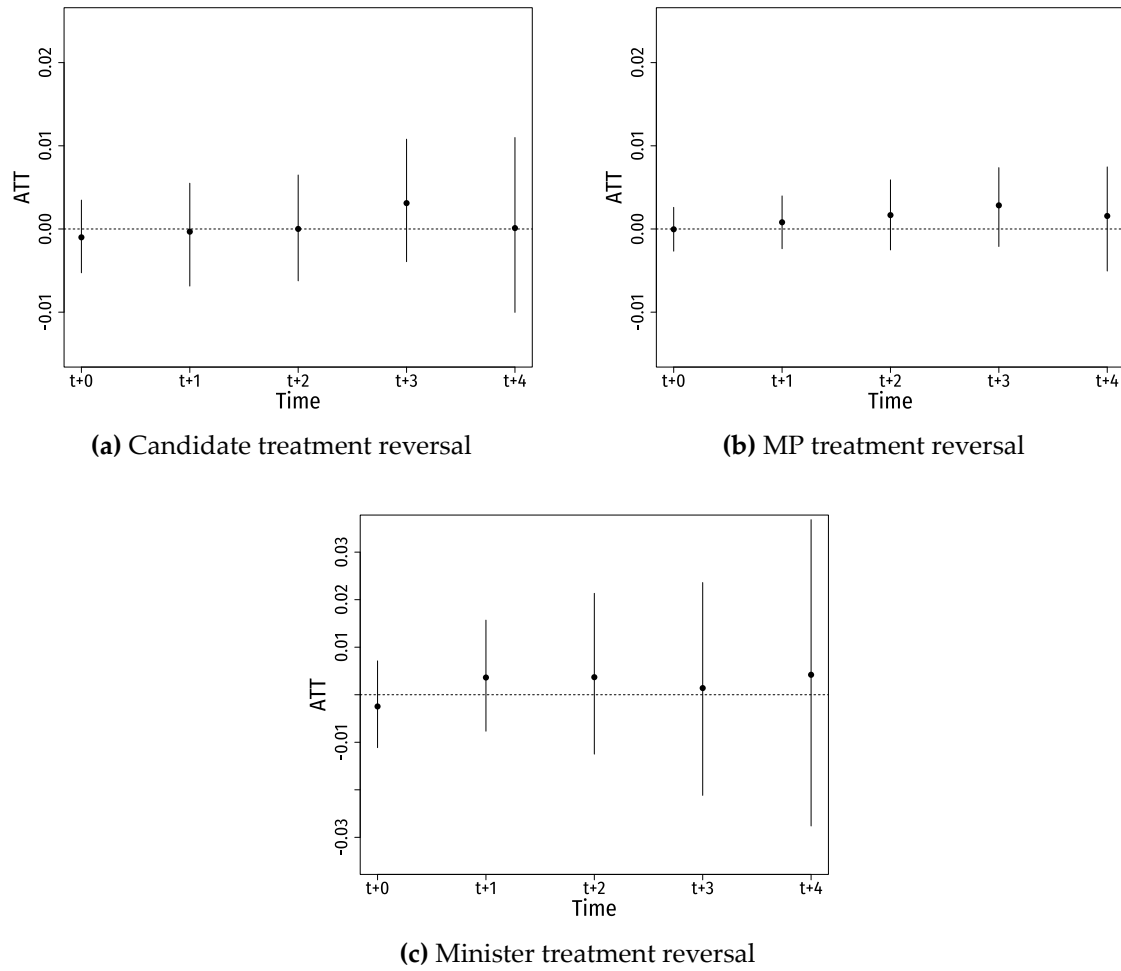


Figure A18. Effects of treatment reversal on turnout (95% confidence intervals)

E.2 Municipality size

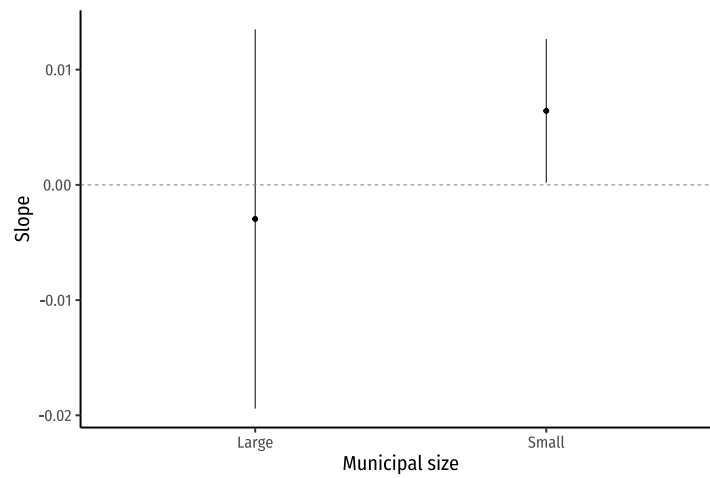


Figure A19. Effect of local candidates on turnout by municipal size, survey data (95% confidence intervals)

E.3 Local attachment

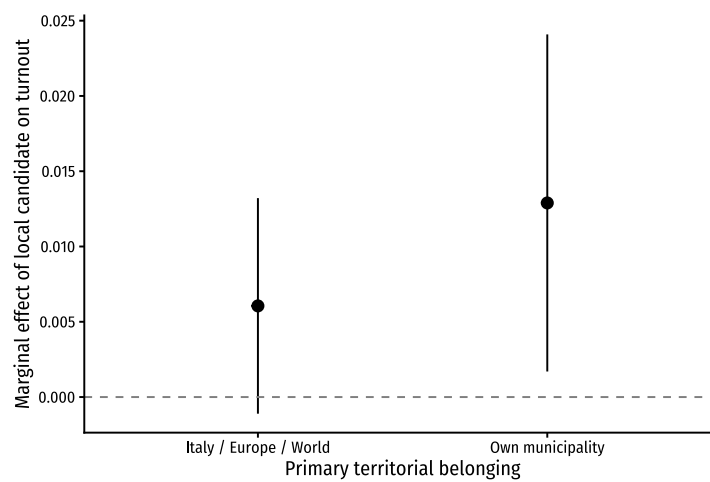


Figure A20. Effect of local candidates on turnout by territorial belonging, survey data (95% confidence intervals)

E.4 Contacts with politicians

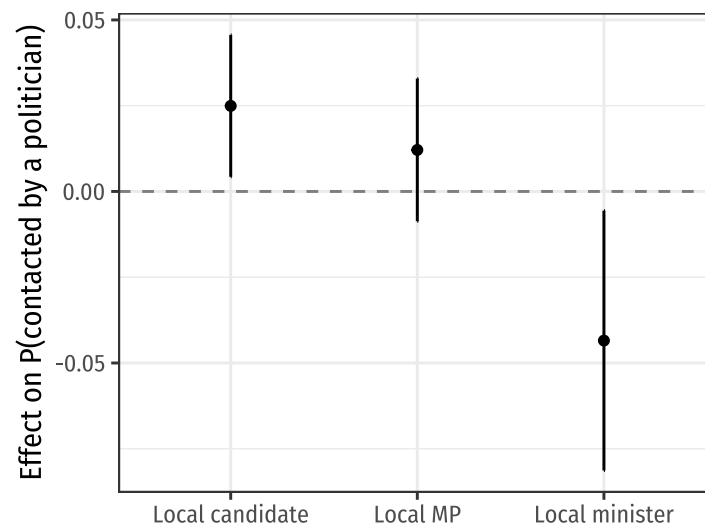


Figure A21. Correlation between treatments and the probability of having being contacted by a politician, survey data (95% confidence intervals)

E.5 Political efficacy

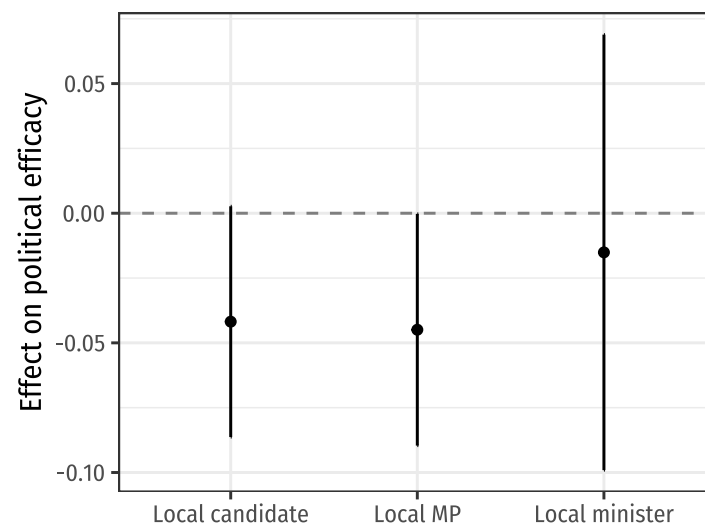
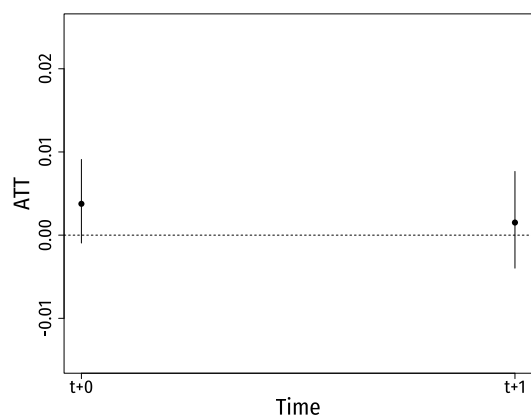
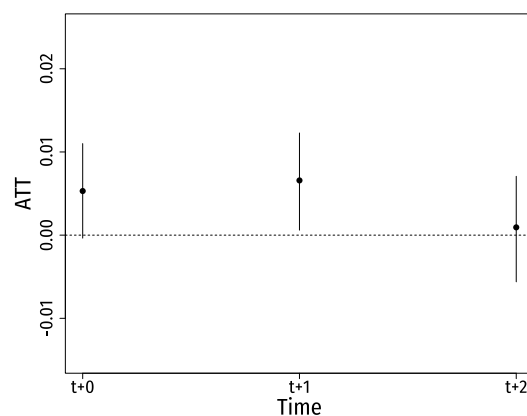


Figure A22. Correlation between treatments and political efficacy, survey data (95% confidence intervals)

E.6 Results split by electoral system

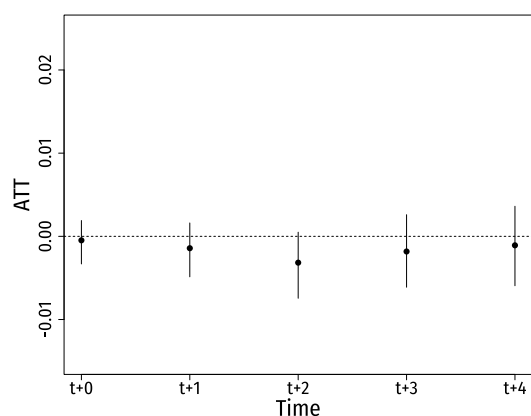


(a) Mixed-member majoritarian (1994-2005)

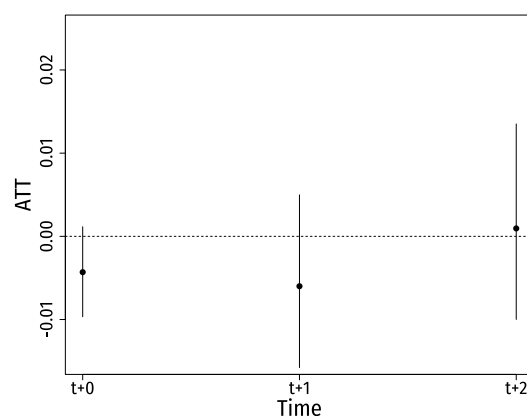


(b) Closed-list PR (2006-2017)

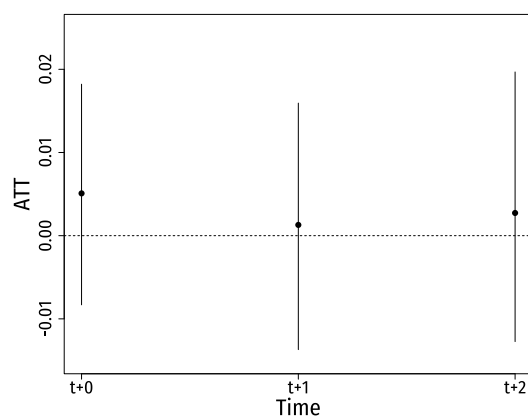
Figure A23. Effects of candidate treatment by electoral system (95% confidence intervals)



(a) Open-list PR (1948-1992)

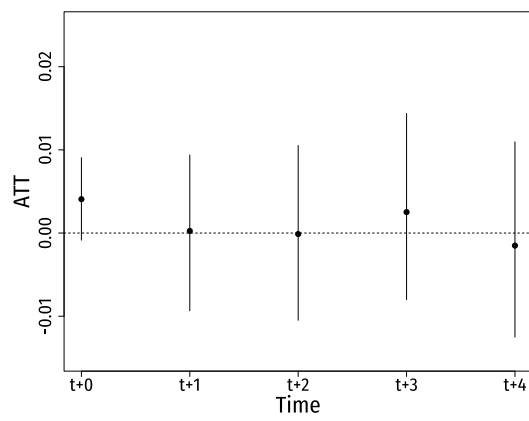


(b) Mixed-member majoritarian (1994-2005)

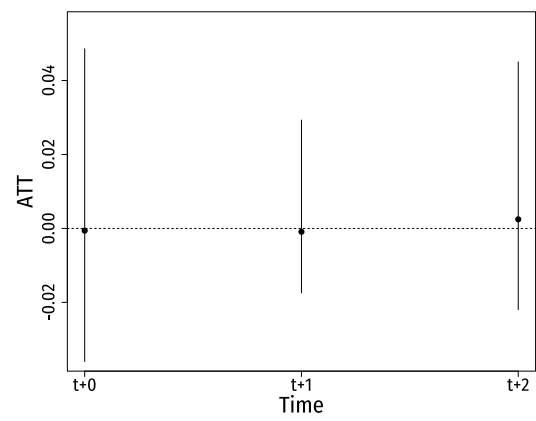


(c) Closed-list PR (2006-2017)

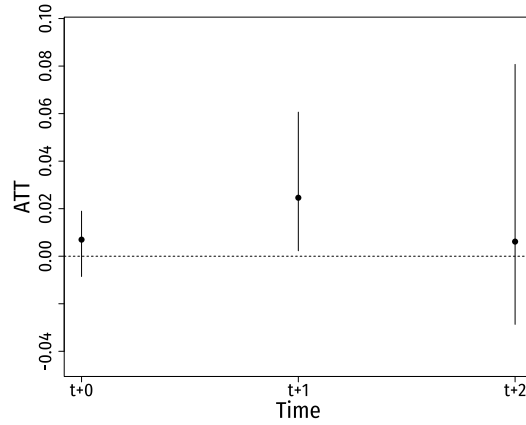
Figure A24. Effects of MP treatment by electoral system (95% confidence intervals)



(a) Open-list PR (1948-1992)



(b) Mixed-member majoritarian (1994-2005)



(c) Closed-list PR (2006-2017)

Figure A25. Effects of minister treatment by electoral system (95% confidence intervals)

References

- Panagopoulos, C. and K. Bailey (2020). “Friends-and-Neighbors” Mobilization: A Field Experimental Replication and Extension’. *Journal of Experimental Political Science*, 7(1): 13–26.